

FREE GUIDE · 5 PARTS

How to hire an executive partner *from the Philippines.*

A short, useful guide for founders and operators. What the role actually is, why the Philippines is a serious answer to it, where to look, what to pay, how to onboard, and the red flags that ruin good hires before they start.

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PART 01

What an executive partner *actually is.*

The phrase gets used loosely. So before you hire one, pin down what you are buying.

An **executive partner** is, technically, a virtual assistant. Same job category, same talent pool, often the same award circuits. The difference is not the title. It is how the person thinks. A VA executes the task you handed them. An executive partner **thinks like the founder** while doing it.

That is the whole distinction. Everything else in this guide follows from it.

What "thinks like the founder" actually means

- **They own outcomes, not tickets.** You hand off the inbox, not "reply to these five emails." They figure out the next four hundred replies without you.
- **They make small decisions for you.** The ones that do not need your input but do need judgment. They bring you the calls that actually require your input, with a recommendation attached.
- **They see seams between functions.** A great VA in marketing notices the CRM is leaking leads. A great VA in ops notices the offer copy is off. They are not staying in their lane because there is no lane.
- **They protect your time aggressively.** Not because you told them to, because they internalized what your time is worth.

What the work actually looks like

The day-to-day is unglamorous and high-leverage. It tends to cluster into four buckets:

- **Executive support.** Inbox triage, calendar ownership, meeting prep, follow-up tracking, correspondence on your behalf.
- **Operations.** Vendor management, internal SOPs, hiring logistics, light bookkeeping support, document ownership.
- **Marketing & content.** Social calendars, newsletter scheduling, brand asset upkeep, content QA.
- **Systems & automation.** CRM hygiene, workflow automations, the boring software glue that keeps the rest from rotting.

One person rarely does *all* of this at expert depth. But the right one does enough of each that you stop being the operational bottleneck. That is the bar.

*The simple test: **after 90 days, do you spend less time on things only you can decide?** If yes, you hired a partner. If you are still the bottleneck, you hired task-execution help, not a founder-grade operator.*

PART 02

Why the Philippines, *specifically*.

You can hire this role anywhere. Eastern Europe, Latin America, South Africa, the US. Each market has tradeoffs. Here is the honest case for the Philippines and where the case breaks down.

The case for

- **English fluency that does not require translation.** The Philippines uses English in school, in business, and in most professional communication. You will not lose nuance in a Slack message or a client email.
- **Cultural fit with US, UK, and Australian work.** Service culture, Western business etiquette, and a strong norm around taking ownership of your work.
- **Mature outsourcing market.** Two decades of BPO and freelance market depth means the talent pool is real. You are not building infrastructure, you are choosing from it.
- **Time zone flexibility.** Most experienced operators are used to working US, EU, or AU hours. The 12-to-15-hour offset works in your favor for "handed-off-overnight" workflows.
- **Cost-to-quality ratio.** Experienced executive partners run roughly \$1,500 to \$3,500 USD per month, full time. That is one-fifth to one-third of a US-based equivalent role, with no meaningful drop in capability.

Where it breaks down

This is not a free lunch. Be honest about what you give up.

- **Time zone is sometimes a hard constraint.** If you need someone in the room during your local business day, the math gets ugly. Real-time meeting density above 4 hours per day burns people out quickly.
- **Infrastructure can be uneven.** Internet and power are good in Metro Manila and Cebu. Outside those, less so. Always ask about backup connections during the interview.
- **The market has a wide quality range.** A \$5/hour VA and a \$20/hour executive partner exist in the same talent pool. The price spread is real and so is the capability spread. Sort accordingly.

THE RIGHT FIT FOR THIS ROLE

Asynchronous-first work, US/EU/AU operating hours, owner-operator businesses, founders running between \$500k and \$20M in revenue who need leverage but cannot yet justify a US-based Chief of Staff.

PART 03

Where to find one, and *what to pay*.

Where the good ones come from

- **Referrals from other founders.** Always the strongest signal. Ask three people who hired Filipino executive partners recently. You will get two names that come up twice.
- **Specialist agencies and matching firms.** Phyllis Song VA, MagicAssistant, Athena, Belay, Persona, Somewhere. They charge a placement fee or markup. In exchange you get vetting and a faster shortlist.
- **OnlineJobs.ph.** The direct-hire marketplace. Cheaper, slower, more variance. Best if you have a strong screening process or a referral to a specific candidate.
- **LinkedIn.** Underused. Search for "Executive Assistant," "Chief of Staff," "Operations Manager" with "Philippines" filter. Look for tenure, not titles.

What to actually pay

Rough monthly ranges in USD, full-time (160 hours per month), as of 2026. These are realistic for direct hires, not agency-billed rates.

TIER	MONTHLY USD	WHAT THIS GETS YOU
Entry VA	\$800 – \$1,200	Task execution. Calendar, inbox, light research. Needs detailed instructions. Best for clear, narrow handoffs.
Senior VA / Specialist	\$1,200 – \$1,800	Owns a function (social, CRM, design, ops). Does the work without you scripting it. Limited cross-domain judgment.
Executive Partner	\$1,800 – \$3,000	Cross-functional operator. Owns the operational layer. Makes judgment calls. Brings problems with proposed solutions.
Chief-of-Staff tier	\$3,000 – \$5,000+	Strategic operator. Can run hiring, vendor negotiations, board prep. Rare. Usually has prior agency or startup-COO experience.

Pay at the top of the band for the work you actually need. Trying to hire a \$3,000-tier operator at \$1,200 is a tax you pay in churn six months later.

A NOTE ON RETAINERS VS HOURLY

Retainer beats hourly for this role, every time. Hourly billing rewards slow work and punishes leverage. A monthly retainer with a defined scope ("you own these outcomes") lets a good operator deploy AI, automations, and shortcuts without penalty. If you find yourself negotiating timesheets, you are buying the wrong thing.

PART 04

How to onboard so you do not waste *the first 90 days.*

The most expensive mistake with this hire is treating the first month as "let them figure it out." A good executive partner will figure it out. But they will figure out the wrong things first, and you will spend month two re-routing them.

Use the structure below. It is boring on purpose.

Week 1: Context dump

- 1 **Record loom walkthroughs of your tools.** CRM, project management, inbox, calendar, payment systems. Two minutes each. They will rewatch these for a month.
- 2 **Share your "what makes me different" doc.** If you do not have one, write a one-page version of how you do business. Voice, defaults, no-go areas, who you do not work with.
- 3 **Introduce them to anyone they will interact with.** Clients, contractors, vendors. A short note from you saves them weeks of awkwardness.

Weeks 2 to 4: Shadow and document

- 1 **Have them sit in on calls.** Even ones they will not directly support. They are absorbing pattern, not content.
- 2 **Ask them to write SOPs for everything they touch.** Even if a SOP exists, having them re-document it from scratch teaches them the work and gives you an updated reference.
- 3 **Weekly 30-minute sync.** Agenda: what landed this week, what is stuck, what they need from you. Not status updates, decisions.

Days 30 to 60: Hand off the second layer

- 1 **Identify your three biggest time leaks.** Be honest. Inbox triage, calendar coordination, follow-up tracking, vendor management, content QA. Pick three.
- 2 **Hand the first one off completely.** Not "help me with my inbox." *"You own the inbox. Here is what I want to see, here is what I never want to see, here is when to escalate."*

- 3 **Repeat with the next two over the following 30 days.** Hand off completely, not partially. Partial handoffs leave you doing the residual work, which defeats the point.

Day 90: The check-in that matters

- 1 **Are you spending less time on things only you can decide?** If yes, the role is working. If no, the scope is wrong, not the person.
- 2 **Are they bringing you decisions, or asking you for the answer?** You want decisions with a recommendation attached. If they are still asking "what should I do," they have not been given enough context yet. Fix that on your end first.
- 3 **Adjust scope and compensation explicitly.** If they have taken on more than you originally hired for, raise the retainer. Quietly under-paying a partner is the fastest way to lose one.

PART 05

Red flags *and green flags.*

Most hires fail in the interview, not in the work. Here is what to actually watch for.

RED FLAGS IN THE INTERVIEW

Walk away if you see most of these:

- Answers in scripted, corporate language. They are auditioning for the role, not telling you how they actually work.
- Cannot name a single client they have improved measurably. Not "I helped them grow." Specific numbers, specific outcomes.
- Talks about hours worked instead of outcomes delivered.
- No portfolio of SOPs, automations, or documents they have built. A real operator has receipts.
- Vague about why they left their last engagement. Especially if they have left multiple recent ones quickly.
- Quotes a rate without asking about scope. Means they have one rate for everything, which means they are anchored on hours.

GREEN FLAGS IN THE INTERVIEW

The signals worth paying for:

- They ask *you* sharp questions early. About scope, about your business, about what success looks like.
- They tell you the last time they pushed back on a client decision, and why.
- They have a clear opinion on retainer vs hourly. Strong operators have already had this argument and won it.
- They use AI tools (Claude, ChatGPT, n8n, Make) as a baseline, not a novelty.
- They show you SOPs or systems they have built. Even small ones.
- They are slightly cautious about taking the role. The eager ones are usually wrong for it.

The three questions that matter most

- 1 **"Walk me through the last 30 days of a client you support."** The answer tells you whether they think in outcomes or in tasks. Watch for specifics: numbers, decisions, judgment calls.
- 2 **"What is something you stopped doing for a client, and why?"** Good operators have opinions on what is worth their time. People who say "I do whatever the client wants" will burn you out by trying to please.
- 3 **"How would you say no to me, if you needed to?"** If they cannot answer this concretely, they will silently absorb work they should be pushing back on. That is how good hires go quiet and quit.

The 30-day exit clause

Always include one. Either side, no penalty. The fit becomes obvious in the first 30 days. Pretending otherwise wastes everyone's time. A confident operator will not flinch at this.